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Did Christopher McCandless lead a fulfilling, adventurous life, or did he make a massive mistake that ended up in his untimely death? Jon Krakauer wrote *Into the Wild*, and he published it in 1996, which became one of his most famous books. The answer we're looking for is in Krakauer's book. Chris McCandless wasn't only a reckless idiot, nor should we completely admire him for his courage and noble ideas. It's a combination of both. Chris did make vital mistakes that cost him his life, and he could've saved himself sooner, yet he died gratified and accepted whatever was coming next. Chris died a happy man, even with all the troubles he went through.

Chris wasn't as incompetent as many people at the time of his death seem to think. While he wasn't an expert at traveling or camping, he still managed to hitchhike extensively across western America and held his own for several months in Alaska. Krakauer recounts a conversation where his friend had said, "Living in the interior bush for an extended period, subsisting on nothing except what you hunt and gather—most people have no idea how hard that actually is. And McCandless almost pulled it off." (185). We know Chris made mistakes during his preparation when coming to Alaska, and despite that, Chris lasted for about one hundred and thirteen days, all alone. He had to hunt game, forage, and rely on books to keep himself alive while documenting his journey.

Even though surviving in the Alaska interior for that long is impressive for the experience that Chris had, he still made decisions that hindered him more than they helped him. If he had been more prepared and hadn't made mistakes, he would've lived. Despite that, Chris ultimately died proud of the way he lived his life. He didn't go out full of regrets and what could've been. For instance, in the text it says, "On the other side of the page, which was blank, McCandless penned a brief adios: 'I have had a happy life and thank the Lord. Goodbye and may God bless all!'" (Krakauer 199). This reveals that Chris McCandless came to acceptance and became satisfied with the life he led until his death.

A note isn't the only proof needed to show that Chris was proud of the last few years he'd spent hitchhiking to Alaska. He took hundreds of beautiful photos during that journey, and the last one just so happened to be of himself, smiling. According to the text, "He is smiling in the picture, and there is no mistaking the look in his eyes: Chris McCandless was at peace, serene as a monk gone to God." (Krakauer 199). Whether this is a way to cope with the mistakes he made and was lying, or was genuinely happy with how everything turned out, nobody will ever know for sure. But for what reason would a dying man have to lie?

Overall, Chris McCandless did in fact make a lot of mistakes during his hitchhiking years. Especially when he finally made his last stop in Alaska. He still pushed through and problem-solved, met new people, formed valuable relationships, and he was happy with what he was doing despite all the trouble he had to go through. Chris died in peace, and it was doing what he loved the most. It's a bittersweet end to his life, because it's suspected that he was ready to go home after some time in Alaska, but couldn't find a way out because of overlooking crucial information. But for all that it's worth, he was fulfilled.